

I See Gold on the Leaves

A BOY POURS THE WINE. Blond, powder blue eyes, hands small on the width of the glass. He twists the bottle and wipes the tip with a cloth. Then slides it into a silver bucket, brimmed with ice, condensate dripping to the carpet. I watch him scurry out of sight to go play with his younger siblings, avoiding eye contact with the guests filling up our dining room. Nora sits across from me at the end of the table. Her eyes are closed, trying to ignore the rampant banter of our guests.

They are rich and loud, talking over one another, contradicting, responding to questions with forgotten points. A yellow light shines in from the patio. The static crash of the ocean fills the gaps in conversation.

“...Montenegro is *certainly* a country worth the money you waste while you’re there.”

“Really?”

“It is not.”

“I feel the same about Paris.”

A breeze blows the drapes in, rising high and white, billowing at the edges. The smell of brine, empty shells of clam, sourdough mopping up the last of the broth.

“No, I always disagree with this! Paris is hot and stuffy and you won’t get treated well. In Montenegro, they always treat you well.”

“Well, I wouldn’t think one goes to Europe expecting to be treated one way or another.”

“It is all in the way they live in Montenegro. They have a saying, have you heard it? *Poco a poco*, they treat life slowly, they don’t engage in the fine discrepancies.”

“For God’s sake that’s a saying all over the world. It’s Spanish for little by little.”

They’re drunk and flush and laughing. A board of soft cheeses circles the table.

“Well, the idea is sound, regardless of the language. Life is meant to be taken one step at a time. You know we could learn a thing or two from those Montenegrins.”

I turn my head away from the commotion and see her across from me. Her eyes communicate several thoughts, jut over to her least favorite guest then back to me with a wink. She sighs, resting her chin in her palm, mimicking their jest with her mouth. I try not to laugh.

Grinning, she leans over the table and says, “I never liked the European wine.”

“The wine is the only reason I went!” someone adds on the other side.

Our guests go off onto another tangent describing all the types of wine in France. I ignore it all, taking Nora’s hand in mine and running my thumb over her thinning fingers. I realize I can see the veins between the bone even in the dim lighting.

“We never got to see much of France, did we,” she says to me.

“I thought you liked Paris.”

“I did. But we never *saw* France. I mean really lived it.”

I chuckle. “There is only so much you can do in one trip.”

“I suppose.” She stares vacantly out past our patio to the black ocean turning in the night.

“Would you like some more wine, my love?” I ask.

“*Amore?*”

“A little bit of Europe comes back to me when I drink.”

The white sits in the bottom of her glass, a puddle that wouldn’t coat the tongue.

“Yes, but just one more will do.”

“Charlie,” I call behind me. A blond head pokes from the corner. “Could you pour your mother another glass?”

“*Now?*” he says, his little brother’s fingers extending from around the wall, snatching at his nose. I wave him over and Charlie returns to the dining room, his tux oversized, a gold button torn off, cuffs undone, hair combed back just as his mother wanted, a frown reaching his chin. Stomping his feet, he makes his way to the wine and pours Nora a heavy handed glass.

“Thank you, darling. You look very handsome,” she says and he can’t fight a smile.

The guests leave after midnight. Charlie and his younger sister Lily, and her younger brother O’Neal, who goes by Neal, or, as he pronounces it, *Meal*, are in bed and well situated in their dreams. Nora is drunk from the wine and unsure of the strength in her legs to take her up the stairs. I help her to the railing at the bottom step. She tries to lift her leg, but stops.

“*Amore?*” she says. “Would you carry me up?”

Light in my arms, her breath of white wine and garlic, happily slapping my cheeks, tugging my ears. By now I can feel the bones of her spine and the protrusion of ribs through her blouse.

“You know, I wish we could have seen other countries too,” she says. “A part of me always wanted to go to the odd places. Like the Arctic. What on Earth is going on in the Arctic?”

“You hate the cold.”

She waves a hand. “You get what I mean. I just wish we saw more of the world.”

“The world was made just for you, Nora. There’s still time to see it.”

In summers we leave the balcony doors open and let the breath of the sea cool the tops of our sheets. With it, comes the hush of the waves, and, in the morning, the sun casting across the room, the clouds strung seaward above the cliffs, a cottage on the beach, the sound of seabirds, the children, asleep, still caught up in those dreams of theirs.

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SHE IS HUMMING A LULLABY AND THE CHILDREN ARE FOLLOWING IN SINGLE FILE. Their heads are short among the overgrown grass. The day is hot and white, the wind coming up the lip of the cliffs and waving the ends of the brush. I stand back for a bit, holding my mother’s urn under my arm and watching them march up towards the peak overhanging the ocean.

In front of his siblings is Charlie, his favorite stick held over his shoulder, a purple bandana he tied to the end, flapping inland. Lily is next. She isn’t much shorter than Charlie and keeps stopping to point out the insects she finds under rocks. Neal is the caboose, snorting when Lily tosses worms at Charlie. Nora leads the way, with an occasional stern glance over her shoulder.

We reach the top and stand behind a rope at the cliff’s edge. Lily and Neal are clinging to Nora’s legs, afraid a great wave might come up and snatch them away. Charlie announces to us that he is not afraid of heights and stands bravely at the ropes hoisting his stick into the air.

“Charlie?” I ask. “Would you like to scatter Nana’s ashes?”

His marble blue eyes drop to the metal urn in my hands. He squints his brow as if to contemplate how they managed to shove Nana into such a little jar. He shakes his head. I do the honors, bending over the rope, waiting for an interval of still air between the upward gusts.

I tip it over. The sand stretches the face of the cliff and dissolves into a wash of white foam. I kneel for a while, watching the last of my mother splash against the rocks. Nora puts a hand on my shoulder. Neal begins to wail. As does Charlie, in his way, without shame, filled with reverence to the trembling pride that he holds so close. Lily is silent, watching her brothers in a knowing melancholy that comes from someone who lives beyond their years.

When it's done, I tuck the urn under my arm and take Nora by the hand. We trail back down the hill to our cottage on the beach. Neal is a mess and halfway down I hand the empty urn to Nora and pick him up. He is asleep by the time we are back on the beach, a cool patch of drool forming on my chest. Lily and Charlie decide they want to race up the beach. Nora and I stay back, taking off our shoes and walking along the rising swash.

"You know," she says holding up the urn. "When it's my turn, I'd like mine to be blue."

"Do they make them blue?"

"Find one that's azure blue. And etched with water lilies."

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CHARLIE WANTS TO LEARN PIANO FROM HIS MOTHER. They sit on a black bench, his head still well below her shoulders. She is teaching him progressions. I am standing against the kitchen door, watching them giggle through their backs.

Two baguettes, cut in half and matted with garlic butter, baking at four hundred. A copper pot we received at our wedding bubbles a bouillabaisse. I use a wooden spoon, the end scorched and fraying, to turn over the stew and to check on the mussels. They are open, the meat contracted and done. I let Charlie and Nora continue playing for a little while before I gather them for dinner.

It's half past seven, the last of the summer sun slips past the horizon, bringing in an orange hue to the silverware, the white linen drapes, across the back of Nora's neck.

"How'd you like the piano? You sounded good," I ask Charlie.

He nods, busy scooping a mussel onto his garlic bread.

"Do you think you'd want to take lessons? There are plenty of great teachers around."

"I want Mama to teach me," he says, a bit of parsley painted to his chin.

I stop eating and bring my hands into my lap.

"Okay, but—"

"Darling, I think that is a wonderful idea," Nora says.

"Yes, Charlie, I think that's great. But, what if Mama can't teach you?" I say slowly.

"Why won't she teach me?"

"Oh, it's not that, I just mean, what if she isn't around to teach you?"

Charlie's lips shine wide caging his crooked teeth between two lines of dimples. "Then I'll wait for her to come back!"

I glance over to Nora. Eyes soft and weary, cheeks losing their last film of fat, a faint smile. I start to speak, but she places a hand on my knee under the table. I let it go.

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THE AFTERMATH OF LILY'S BIRTHDAY INVOLVES A QUEUE OF SEDANS PICKING UP GIRLS IN INSECT COSTUMES. Glitter fused to hardwood floor, half a spider-shaped cake gouged at the arms, eight burnt candles, card stock, ribbons, a hundred dollar check to the man with the snakes.

Lily is sprawled out on the hammock, exhausted from her day of hosting, snoring faintly with chocolate frosting at the corners of her mouth. Nora gets her a blanket while I attempt to corral the bits of debris scattered about the house.

Charlie and Neal are sitting together on the beach, watching the waves grow as the sun completes behind the house. Charlie's stick, its purple bandana drooping, is driven into the sand. I walk out and sit down. We chat a bit about the party. Charlie's legs are apart and he's forming pyramids in the sand between them. Neal sits close, mimicking his brother's movements.

"Are they gone?" Charlie asks.

"Yes, they just left."

"Can I have cake?" Neal says in glee.

"Of course, go ask Mama to help you."

Neal gets up, sand spilling from his shorts, and sprints back inside. Charlie gathers sand in his palm and lets it fall between his fingers.

"You don't want any cake?"

"Too sweet. Hurts my teeth," he says shaking his head.

“Alright,” I say trying to remember his last dentist appointment. “How was your piano practice today?”

“Good. Mama taught me Lavender.”

“Lavender’s Blue?”

“Uhuh.”

“Can you play the whole thing?”

“Only the first half.”

“That’s great Charlie. Do you think you could play for us? I’d love to hear it.”

He shakes his head and hunches over his pile of sand.

“Come on, your sister would love it. I think it would make her birthday something special.”

Charlie smirks and drives a fist into the pyramid, embarrassed at the prospect of making his sister happy.

“Come on, it’ll be great.” I stand and pick him up under the arms. He hoists his stick from the sand and parades it back into the house. Inside, Nora and Neal are at the cake and he is pointing at the eyeball he wants her to cut out. Lily is awake, the blanket drawn over her shoulders like a cape. I gather us all to sit in the dining room. Charlie’s face is red and eyes drawn to the tile. For a reason beyond our knowledge, he bows before he sits at the piano. Lily is giddy in anticipation. Charlie bends over the keys. He freezes. Nora has to get up to remind him where to start.

The notes come as irregular thuds, but the tune is nice and we sway to the rhythm. At the end he stands and bows again, his hands clasped behind his back. Lily cheers and laughs, clapping at the clear resurrection of Beethoven. Neal's focus is still on his cake.

Nora and I put the kids to sleep and lie awake in our bed. The moon is above the ocean, reflecting a milky white pool through the open balcony doors. Our hands are in the air, feeling the weight of the light on our palms. A wind blows a whisper through the trees.

"I didn't like those Tanner twins," she says, stretching out her fingers.

"Who were they?"

"Dark hair, each with a matching bow. Sydney's kids."

"Ah, that's right. She's getting divorced, you know?"

"They've been '*getting divorced*' for several years now."

I laugh and pinch her knuckles with mine. "What did the Tanner kids do?"

"They spent the whole party inserting themselves to the center of attention, one of them even blew out a candle."

"That's a shame."

"Lily didn't care, of course. She'd be happy if everyone blew out a candle. I'm glad she's growing up sweet." She takes my hand in hers and lowers it between us. "Remember when I found out I was pregnant with Charlie and I said I thought it was going to be twins?"

"I do."

"Thank God it wasn't. One Charlie is enough to deal with."

A pair of seagulls fly past the moon, blinking the room dark.

“How are you feeling? You said your shins were aching,” I ask.

“They’re alright now. Not so bad when I’m not standing.”

“Can I get you anything?”

“No, darling, I’ll be alright.”

She turns over into me and we watch the moon sparkle on far out swells. We talk about our trip to Vancouver and how the seaplanes landed in the bay and how she always thought she could be a great pilot. She tells me she wants to try that dumpling place again and ice skating and to knit scarves for the children. I kiss the top of her head and say that all the world and all its places and all its people were made just for her. She says that it simply isn’t true. I tell her I’d take her anywhere she wanted. She says the time for that is over. I start to cry. She takes my head in her arms. She tells me there isn’t a thing that can be done about it. I tell her how sorry I am and how I love her and how I can’t imagine letting her go.

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NORA WAS GONE BY THE TIME THE LEAVES BLEW OFF THEIR STEMS. It was cold and sunny the day I brought her ashes home. I put her on the mantel next to the undecorated Christmas tree. Neal and Lily had stopped crying by then, but seeing the metal gourde next to the tree like some sick joke of a present brought it all back up. Charlie spent the day in the recliner which used to belong to Nora’s father. He said he wanted to ‘watch Mama in the sunlight.’

I sit in the kitchen after spending the afternoon wrapping gifts, edges of which lacking the traditional perfection that my kids have come to expect on Christmas day. Lily is on the hammock,

Neal beside her as she impresses with a reading of *Matilda*. Charlie is at the piano, playing and replaying the last melodies that he learned.

“Hey, Charlie?” I call from the kitchen. The music stops. He turns to me. “Would you want to help me make dinner?” He agrees and closes the lid on the keys. He snuffles his way into the kitchen. The sun is still well above the horizon and coming through the blinds in a dusty spotlight.

“What should I do?” he asks.

“Why don’t you grab that stool and come over here.”

I show him how to grate the garlic. He finds it fun to see it come out in a paste on the other end and makes a joke about it looking like snot. I turn to devein the shrimp. Once he’s done with the garlic, he helps me fill the pot with water, keeps an eye on the pasta, adds the shrimp, stirs it in. By the end, he’s pretty well adjusted and we have it together and hot in our largest pan. I go out and call in Neal and Lily.

Four plates, MADE IN ITALY, mosaic patterns of yellow and green. There’s a fifth, but it sits alone in the cabinet. I serve Charlie first. He wants extra shrimp and I use the tongs to pinch over two more. I grab the second plate when little Neal comes marching in. He has Charlie’s stick, the purple bandana trailing behind, hoisting the point into the air like a sword. Charlie, seeing his stick wielded by an unworthy individual, tries to rip it from his hands.

“Give it back Neal. This isn’t a toy,” he says.

Neal stands firm and lifts the stick even higher.

“It’s mine, give it back!”

“Never!” Neal shouts.

I put the pan back on the stove. “Neal, give your brother his stick back.”

“No!”

“Give it back!” Charlie dives for it and tries to wrestle it from his hands. Lily stands quiet in the door frame.

“Neal, would you please just give it back to him.”

Before I can snatch it from them both, they tumble to the floor, twisting and kicking and screaming, the stick swishing in the air. Lily steps back. I reach a hand but they turn over and the wood comes around and thwacks me on the side of the head. I keel over shouting. Charlie tosses Neal onto his back and the stick snaps against the floor. The broken end flies up and hits the pan’s handle, sending it spinning off the stove. The boys scramble out of the way. Dinner comes crashing down, scampi shoots out across the tile, shrimp clinging to fusilli like lifeboats, the smell of lemon rising, there’s that garlic too that Charlie did a fine job of grating.

The four of us stand in a semicircle around the mess, watching the steam billow up like a bonfire, sauce pooling towards the grout. I attempt a smile but lose it. I clear my throat, smile again, lose it again, and bend down. I take the pan by the handle and more of it falls out.

There it is, I think, on the floor between us, a steaming pile of nothing. It’s wet and sticking, my shoes peppered, my ear throbbing. Neal leans over to grab a shrimp and Lily pulls him back. I try to scoop some back into the pan but it burns my hand.

Charlie is the first to speak. “Papa, I—”

“Shut it, Charlie. Please.”

“If Neal hadn’t—”

“I don’t give a shit what Neal did. Cut it out.”

“Well, if he hadn’t taken my—”

“I said shut your fucking mouth Charlie!”

And then comes the shouting and the cursing and the screaming of all the things I’m not supposed to say. And before long, I’m kicking the pan across the floor and stomping the scampi flat, slipping and falling and crying about it all. The children standing back without a word. Neal, holding half a broken stick, lip trembling, watery eyes trailing to his sister and brother watching the man who calls himself their father crumple in a pile of shrimp and butter and finely grated garlic.

My wailing goes on until the sun sets. Lily, bless her heart, places a cup of water by my side and takes her brothers outside, leaving me to soak in the cold and mushy scampi. I can hear them out the kitchen window. I figure they might be sitting in a circle on the sand. The ocean is loud and I can’t make out what they’re saying, but the sound of their voices eases it. My choked sobs begin to fade and pretty soon I’m just lying there, breathing in through my nose and out through my mouth. I find myself again and stand. I take off my shirt, pants, and socks and toss it into the mess of scampi. I shovel it all into a trash bag, then I take a shower with the dark.

When I come back downstairs, dressed, hair washed, a brush and a floss for good measure, I find the children cleaning the floor with our dining room tablecloth. I laugh. A sober, lifted laugh that comes from being wasted of everything except that which amuses us.

We eat at the table off of Charlie’s plate with the two extra shrimp. There is a silent agreement among us to not bring it up and, in its place, we joke about what Santa might bring.

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IT'S LATE NOW NORA. The moon is coming in off the ocean, the smell of scampi somehow still present throughout the house. We are in your grandfather's recliner at the foot of the mantel. The fire is lit and our children are piled on me with a blanket pulled over. All the lamps are off. Only the cracking logs bring color, licking the room with golden swirls.

We are looking up at the photo of you on the Vancouver pier, pointing to the seaplanes landing across the bay. You are sitting in an urn beside it, azure blue and etched with water lilies, like you asked. You always liked those.

The weight of our children in my arms. Their small breaths. Our cottage on the beach with the view of the morning sun, the clouds and the cliffs, the constant crash of the shore. The Christmas tree is bare of ornaments, the branches are stiff and pointed, the leaves gold against the light emerging below the mantel. All of us are here Nora, the remains of your memory, the whole world, made just for you, pressed up against my chest.